Animal Dreams

By Jennifer Maisel

(Begin in a fetal position on the floor)

NATALIE: I wonder when they'll tell me about the cancer - is this the wrong thing to be happening to my body? Maybe it's the right thing, maybe it's the only reaction to the world my body can have, maybe it's the only way it can express itself, make itself heard, going out of control, multiplying chaos, anarchy. We try to contain the revolution of cells with knives and poisons and affirmations. What if those cells are my battle against the world? - a way of growing stronger to combat the daily and the lifelong, to make more of just me against the world.

INTRODUCTION

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(Natalie is dressed in a hospital gown. Behind her, a hospital bed holds an image of her body in fetal position. Natalie looks down at her body. There is the sound of whirring machinery.)

NATALIE: *(Natalie has now "left" her body and is free to move about the stage)* I don't recognize that body at all. I mean even if you were to take me into a lineup of bodies and force me choose . . . It's so . . . slack, soft tired skin. Look at that razor stubble-I mean the legs. I used to let the legs go an extra day or two but I always shaved under the arms. I didn't like the way it looked when I didn't shave under the arms. I smelled a little rancid too when I didn't. That is one sorry-looking case. (Looks around her to call) Could someone around here just take a minute and, y'know, shave her under the arms please? It

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would only take a minute. Look, you get so convinced she can hear you, that she could respond if only given the right stimulus, give her a little dignity, why don't you? Oh, to hell with it.

All the positions you put your body in over a lifetime and when push comes to shove this is the one it chooses to remember. It's a good cliche, but not all that comfortable without the waves in the amniotic fluid keeping you afloat. *(To the body on the bed)* Why don't you revert back to one of the good positions, huh? Don't you remember any of the good ones? Try this one. *(She perches on the stool, legs up and splayed apart, head back.)* Oh c'mon, this one always worked. What about-*(Gets off the stool and bends over it, looking back coyly over her shoulder. Tries a look of passion.}* You are no fun at all. You've gotta remember. It hasn't been that long, has it? The body's supposed to remember these things. Like a bicycle, right?

They're not sure whose hand they hold. They're not sure whether it can hear them. They're not sure if they're doing any good at all. They're not sure if they know who she is anymore. They can label her-parts of what she was-Mom. Lover. Wife. Sixth-Grade Teacher. Friend. . . Patient. . . Statistic. They're not sure if she is anymore.

(A school bell rings. As a teacher.) According to the medical profession a coma is the state from which a person cannot be aroused. According to the medical profession there are fifteen stages of coma-stage 1 showing no response to the outside world and stage 15 the most. . . social. According to the medical profession, Glascow's fifteen-point coma scale is also a crock. It just depends on who you talk to.

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Maybe we're just too tired to wake up. Maybe it's just not worth the effort. Maybe there's a comfort in the deep irreverence of ignoring the commotion and the congestion of the everyday. Maybe it's just too painful to be awake right now. Maybe it's time to heal. Maybe I just need a rest! I need a rest!

(Composes herself) In the deep stages I've been able to escape the body and watch the remnants of it metastasizing into one connected mass of small cancerous lumps. I keep my eyes focused inward and note the proliferation of cells like a dandelion patch gone wild and I blow one small tumor into pieces that take root where they fall. I make a wish. And I walk through the inside of my body noting the holocaust of my being, the radiation having killed the healthy and not the sick, the florid growth, the blood full of lumpy cells. And I notice, my wish hasn't come true. This is still the body they say belongs to me.

Celia, my daughter, sits by me and tells me it's OK to let go. To let go. It's OK to let go. How do you know. Trying to get rid of me? . . . How do you know it's OK? What if I let go and there's nothing? What if I let go to nothing? Hold tight! *(Extends hands in front of her. Four irregular breaths. Four more regular breaths.)*

Your hand is warm. I can feel that tic of blood at the bottom of your thumb. I'd put my lips there when you were a baby. You wonder if I like it here. You wonder if I know you. You wonder if I know where I am. Don't let go! Don't bring me out of it. It will hurt. God! If you bring me out of it, it will hurt. I'm not coming out of it again. Do you hear me? I am not coming out of it again.

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Don't let go of my hands now. You brought me back in here. Don't let go of them. . . .

You know as much as they tell you about the inevitability of fate-you are very concerned because you don't want to end up like me. You tell people you take care of yourself You say it's not heredity but environment. You say . . .Don't let go of my hands. Do not let go of my hands, young lady. Where do you think you're going? Come back here. Come back here.

Things I can tell you that you just might not know: There are times when I am trapped in my body in a heavy stupor. One of those stupors like after a really bad drunk. One of those times you struggle to get to the surface only to find-out it's not the place that you want to be.

There are times when I'm not in my life as it is anymore but as it was. I am teaching. I am falling in love again. I'm watching Mom die. My body lets me go. I am in the room, I am on the street, I am flying over the world seeing places I never made it to. I am visiting the people I love and they feel me there but they can't quite put a name to it. My body lets me go. I want to kick it. I want to punch it. I want to scratch great holes in the skin and watch the blood well up. I want to pinch it black and blue and scream, "You miserable thing, what good have you been for me? What have you been doing to me? How dare you betray me like this? How dare you?"

But I can't bite and I can't tear or scratch. My body lets me go and the freedom becomes unbearable and I want to be back inside the confines of my body, if only to know my limitations.

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I guess you just have to be there. *(To her husband)* Oh . . . What are you doing here? You hate hospitals. You hate antiseptic smell not really masking, cotton swabs, TVs positioned high above the bed. You hate me. You live that moment when your hand grasped the. . . breast. . . over and over. It was sex, it was skin, it was touching, absorbing, culminating. . . like so many times before, so many times before, we don't have to speak. . . we've never had to speak. Then you say. . . "What's that? Feel that. What's that? Feel that." Ruined the mood, I can say that much. This is how you'll remember me now.

(School bells rings. As teacher speaking in a student's voice.) I was going to bring something very special to show and tell today, teacher, but I must have lost them on the way. No I did, really, look. *(She bares her chest, showing two big scars winding where her breasts used to be.)* I'll look for them and bring them tomorrow, I promise. They must be around here somewhere. I'll look real hard. I swear. *(School bell rings again.)*

I wonder. I wonder when they tell me about the cancer is this the wrong thing to be happening to my body? Maybe it's the right thing, maybe it's the only reaction to the world my body can have, maybe it's the only way it can express itself, make itself heard, going out of control, multiplying chaos, anarchy. We try to contain the revolution of cells with knives and poisons and affirmations. What if those cells are my battle against the world? A way of growing stronger to combat the daily and the lifelong, to make more of just me against the world. What if I somehow agreed to let the doctor cut out my strength?

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(The machine whirring grows louder.) They say go into the light. They say come back to us. I can't. I can't. If I just stay here. If I just stay here. If I could just stay here. *(The sounds of the machinery. . . the heart monitor, the dripping, take over as the world around Natalie becomes dark. . . .)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jennifer Maisel
Book: Even More Monologues for Women by Women
ISBN: 0325002479
Publisher: Heinemann
Date(Month/Year): March 2001

AWARDS

MN State Qualfier – DI - Female

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